

prints, but it takes the same time at the best quality, leaving the HP 4355 and Lexmark lagging behind. The Lexmark is the slowest of all the MFDs at photo printing, taking an agonising 18 minutes! These three, the lowest-priced in the lot, display black text print quality at par with each other, while in the colour print department, the HP and Epson are better. The Lexmark produces prints that appear sprinkled with ink droplets.

Amongst the Brother DCP-330C and the HP C4188 and 5610, the HP MFDs are the fastest at normal-quality text printing, but the 5610 is the slowest of the three once you enable colour and turn up the quality. Text prints are good with all the MFDs, but the HP C4188 is the best with our combi-document and photos. The Brother MFD does print well, but the colours appear faded—as with all MFDs from Brother.

The Canon PIXMA MP460 is clearly the fastest, and even manages excellent photo quality in that time. This one is probably more suited for a small photo studio rather than for an office. It doesn't disappoint with text and combi-document printing, either.

Scanning And Copying

The Lexmark X4270 scans really fast—taking just 9 seconds for black-and-white—but is one of the slowest when it comes to colour scans. The HP 4355 and Epson were slower than the

Lexmark in the black-and-white scans.

The HP C4188 scans fast in black-and-white, but is a little slow at colour. Still, it captures the shades of the colours on the IT8 card very well. The scanner on the Brother DCP-330C is also good, and the HP 5610 falters while distinguishing between adjacent shades in the dark and light colours.

The HP 5680, though looks similar to the 5610, takes up to twice the time to scan a full-colour photo at 600 dpi. The fastest among the 5680, Canon PIXMA MP460, and the Brother DCP-240C is the Brother, taking just 13.8 seconds for a black-and-white scan. It also captures the most detail in the scanner test among the above three, followed closely by the MP460.

The MP460 copies at good speeds—though not at the fastest—and the quality of the copies is so good, it's difficult to distinguish between the original and the copy at first look! The rest copy with acceptable quality, and none of them elicit any complaints. The Epson and Lexmark are the slowest at colour copies, so they aren't suitable for making copies of your colour presentations if you're in a hurry.

PROFESSIONAL MFDs

The MFDs in this category sport special features such as the ability to print photographs at professional quality, networking, and more. Prices typically start at around Rs 15,000 and can go

up to Rs 25,000 and beyond. Naturally, these fall outside the realm of SoHos and small businesses.

The heavyweights here are the Brother MFC-440CN, Canon PIXMA MP600, Epson Stylus Photo RX650, and the HP Photosmart C6188 All-in-One.

Features Printing

Two of the MFDs, the Brother and the Epson, feature piezo-electric printing, while the HP and Canon MFDs are based on thermal inkjet printing technology. The Brother and Canon have



HP Photosmart C6188 All-in-One
Master of all trades!

the usual four (Cyan, Magenta, Yellow, Black) ink cartridges each, but the HP and Epson have six (Black, Cyan, Magenta, Light Magenta, Cyan, Light Cyan, Yellow). The extra cartridges should increase the accuracy of colour reproduction, and our tests will verify if this is indeed the case.

Scan, Copy, And Fax

The Brother MFC-440CN is expensive—probably thanks to the network feature and the huge 400-page fax memory, which lets you receive faxes even when you run out of paper. It has a scan resolution of 600 x 1200 dpi, which is the lowest of the lot. The HP C6188 boasts of a high scan resolution of 4800 x 4800 dpi, while the Epson scans at 3200 x 6400 dpi. The fax MFDs—the HP and the Brother—feature ADFs and both flatbed and sheet-fed scanners, while

Footnotes

This is not about any particular category of MFD, but about all the MFDs in general and our experiences with them.

HP has a Dial-a-Cartridge system in many cities. If you run out of ink, you can dial a toll-free number and order a cartridge, which arrives at your doorstep.

A general nuance about HP MFDs is the long time they take to install the software. On our test rig, it took us 15 minutes on average for all the HP MFDs in the test. Though this is a one-time affair, HP needs to pay some attention to this—it's plagued us for a few years now.

Brother MFDs are good for offices—that's what they're meant for—but a peculiar thing we noticed is a seeming Obsessive Compulsive Disorder: they waste around two minutes cleaning the cartridge every time they're switched on for a photo print. And *despite* that, the colours are faded—we're left wondering what kind of cleaning was done. Another issue we faced with Brother was that none of their MFDs could pick up the 160 gsm photo paper, so we had to replace it with the lighter 110 gsm paper to get things moving.

All the MFDs come with software suites that include photo editing as well as OCR software. These are more than sufficient for general need.